

Liberated hardware products

So what are his new initiatives?

“Several,” he says.

‘Liberated hardware’ is hardware that can run free software but isn’t necessarily designed to do so. At the LibreTech.Shop, over the past year, Abhas has listed quite a few ‘liberated hardware’ products that offer free software on a device by default. These include:

- Mobile phones running LineageOS, the open source Android distribution available for several devices (or Ubuntu Touch, designed primarily for mobile devices, or PostmarketOS, tiny and under 10MB in size).
- Wireless routers running OpenWRT, meant for embedded devices.
- ‘Smartwatches’ that run a free OS called AsteroidOS, the FOSS operating system for smart watches.
- Liberated computers (laptops and desktops) that offer a perfect GNU/Linux experience out-of-the-box and are powered by Coreboot (the free software BIOS replacement). Coreboot describes itself as “an extended firmware platform that delivers a lightning fast and secure boot experience on modern computers and embedded systems. As an open source project it provides auditability and maximum control over technology.”
- Home automation solutions, including wireless switches and Wi-Fi tubelights to start with. Wireless switches enable you to switch on/off a mains outlet over the network. A Wi-Fi tubelight lets you switch the tubelight over the network as well as change its colour and brightness, all with 100% free software and without requiring internet access or a proprietary mobile app.

Abhas says: “What I am attempting to do is remove the last bit of hesitation that someone might have with using free software



in more places. If I can sell the same products that people might purchase off-the-shelf with free software pre-loaded, that might be the convenience they’re searching for. The ‘sales’ are not really encouraging right now, but I am hoping that setting up a stall at various community events might help change that.”

“I’m trying to tell somebody about the beauty of GNU/Linux, and I don’t have a USB disk at hand to show it to them live on their computer. Or to even install a thing that they can test and see first-hand. We also need to fix computers sometimes, or to install something. We need to have something all the time,” he explains.

Since he got started in the late 1990s, how has his work changed, and how has the discourse changed?

“My vision was to run a business where I could charge people for running free software for them. It remains the same even today. Ironically, it’s getting more difficult to do that sometimes, as compared to the early 2000s. At that time, people were used to the idea of installing software on their own computers,” Abhas adds.

Tech... and politics

Does he agree with the view that the Indian techie often doesn’t understand

— or care for — the politics involved in technology? Says Abhas: “It depends on who you talk to and which circles you’re in. But a lot of people do not. That is true.”

Thankfully, as he puts it, journalists and activists are more aware of this aspect today. “They understand the dangers of proprietary tracking systems.”

He argues: “The respect for the freedom we have only grows when we lose some of it or all of it. But many have not thought about losing freedom.”

Server space

Two decades back, when we first met, Abhas was very much into the server space. Does his passion for the server continue?

“Yes. I still work with servers. It’s important to do self-hosting at the individual or family level,” he says.

Many people want to use free software. One option is to host it yourself. You need a small server that you would pay for. When you install your own software, you run your email, activity-powered social presence, microblogging, and videos. Use it to sync pics from your phone, or run a chat server. All of that is possible, he points out.

But it doesn’t come easy. The problems one encounters can be twofold — most people don’t know